

GatewayGuard Security Guide — REWRITE DRAFT

Document Name: GatewayGuard_GuideRewrite-Draft

Last Modified: 2026-08-19 09:50 ET

Last Editor: Claude.ai (Cloud)

Machine: CGDELL

Status: DRAFT FOR REVIEW — not a replacement for `windows_security_walkthrough_guide_v9.docx` until Bill approves

Source: `ProjectDocs/GatewayGuard_GuideV9-SourcePack-2026-08-15-1436.md` (68,879-byte source, 9,363 words)

Change History Log:

2026-08-15 18:38: Created. Full rewrite for the senior reader per Bill's 2026-08-13 audience decision. Six open decisions applied as recommendations, each marked **[DECISION]** in place.

2026-08-19 09:50: Front help section replaced with a four-line gate per Bill. The other 33 lines moved to a *Getting help* addendum at the back, ransomware first. **Four stale pointers to the old section name corrected** — lines 141 and 148 named in Claude Code's review, plus two more it did not find, at the unfamiliar-account warning and the Phase 3 gate.

2026-08-15 18:38: Reconciled against `WebSite/html/` and `ProjectDocs/GatewayGuard_WebsiteSourcePack-2026-08-15-1751.md` under RULE W-07. Twelve corrections applied — see RECONCILIATION below.

READ THIS BEFORE THE DRAFT — what changed and why

Six decisions were open from `GuideRewritePlan-2026-08-13-2207.md`. **I applied my recommendation for each rather than stall.** Every one is marked **[DECISION]** at the point it takes effect, so any single reversal is a local edit and not a rewrite.

#	Decision	Applied
1	Phase 4 — Avira	Cut. Generalised into Step 2 as "another antivirus that will not uninstall"
2	Phase 3 — incident response	Gated. Full procedure kept, behind a stop-and-decide page
3	PowerShell / Task Scheduler	Walled. Moved to "Advanced — optional" at the back
4	Cross-reference to the tool	Yes, light. Named per the Checkup Name Rule; links to the free pages
5	Advertising ID / Diagnostic data	Reconciled. Presented as privacy choices with a recommendation, matching what Checkup does
6	Glossary hardware terms	Trimmed. SO-DIMM, DDR4/DDR5, MPN, page file removed

Also applied throughout:

Audience. Every "the user" is gone. The reader owns this PC. Where v9 said "*ask the user first*," the replacement is *write it down and change nothing yet* plus a route to help.

Naming. All 19 names follow `NamingStandard-2026-08-09-1345.md` and N-07 capitalization. **The two named exceptions are preserved and must not be "corrected"** — Enhanced Phishing Protection, BitLocker Data Encryption.

Coverage. The three absent settings are written: Defender Periodic Scanning, Fast Startup, Wake on LAN. The four thin ones are expanded: Enhanced Phishing Protection, Remote Desktop, Advertising ID, Diagnostic Data.

Rules. No "whether", no "whereas", no "switch" as a verb, no superlatives. "Open-source" survives once, in the Chromium glossary entry, where it is factually correct.

Stopping points. Marked at the end of each phase. v9 asked for 1–3 hours unbroken with no breaks marked.

Identity. Cover, publisher, copyright, edition label, version date — none of which existed.

RECONCILIATION AGAINST THE 19 WEBSITE PAGES — RULE W-07

Twelve corrections applied. The website pages are further along than v9 was, and on these points they were right and the draft was wrong or thin.

#	Setting	Correction
1	Fast Startup	Path was incomplete — Hardware and Sound was missing, and Shutdown settings was not named
2	Fast Startup	Added the greyed-out-boxes warning; readers get stuck there
3	Fast Startup	"A few seconds" replaced with the measured ten to thirty seconds
4	Fast Startup	Removed a false instruction — the draft said restart afterwards. It takes effect at the next shutdown
5	Fast Startup	Added the note that scan reminders are unaffected
6	Wake on LAN	Tone corrected. The draft said turn it off. The tool keeps this item unselected by default — it is a choice, not a harden
7	Wake on LAN	Added the magic packet option for readers who keep it on
8	Wake on LAN	Added the definite answer on pre-Windows startup screens — W-08 forbids the dead end the draft left
9	Wake on LAN	Added "no restart needed", and that both adapters must be done
10	Wake on LAN	Added the remote-access scam warning , FTC-sourced, carried from the tool
11	BitLocker	Added the Windows 11 Pro path and the Manage BitLocker check; added initial encryption time
12	BitLocker	Recovery key: four storage options, at least two , and saved before encryption finishes

Plus a systematic gap the website exposed: the guide had no undo instructions anywhere. The website template carries *How to revert it* on all 19 pages. Added to Fast Startup, Wake on LAN, Advertising ID, Diagnostic Data and Remote Desktop.

Two things on the live site that need your decision — not fixed here

The page footers say "Source code is included with every download." Under the source-available licence that may be accurate, but `WebsiteStandards` requires "source-visible" or "fully auditable" rather than anything that reads as open-source. Worth a consistent phrase across the site and the guide.

The same footers say "No subscription — ever." Annual updates are priced at \$12.99/yr. Optional updates are not a subscription, but the line invites the comparison and a buyer may feel misled. Worth rewording before launch.

Still needed before this ships, and not in my hands: the Table of Contents and index page numbers must be generated in Word (that defect exists at source, not just in the export), the five editions regenerated together, and every measurement re-verified by Claude Code.

GatewayGuard Security Guide

Windows 11 — a plain-English walkthrough for your own PC

Compact edition — 12 pt Version 10 · [DATE TO BE SET AT RELEASE]

Published by **GatewayGuard LLC**, Brunswick, Maine gatewayguard.co

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Larger print available. This guide comes in five sizes — 12, 14, 16, 18 and 20 point. If this one is hard on your eyes, use a larger one. They contain exactly the same words.

What this guide is

This is a step-by-step walkthrough of the security settings on your own Windows 11 computer. You do not need any technical background. Nothing here assumes someone is sitting beside you.

You will check about twenty settings, one at a time. For each one, the guide tells you where it lives, what it does, what it should be set to, and how to change it if it is wrong.

It also covers what to do if you find something harmful — a family of fake programs that has been spreading through search-engine advertising. That part is at the back, and you only read it if you need it.

What this guide is not

It is not a program and it changes nothing on your computer. **You make every change yourself**, so you always know what happened.

If you would rather have those checks run for you, **GatewayGuard Checkup** is our tool that walks through the same settings on screen and asks your permission before each change. This guide stands on its own and does not require it.

Before you start

Have these ready:

Your phone, with internet. You will use it for a few steps where signing in on the computer itself is a bad idea.

Pen and paper. You will write things down.

Your Microsoft account password, if you use one to sign in to Windows.

Your Windows PIN.

Set aside about an hour for the first two phases. Stopping points are marked. You can close the guide at any one of them and pick up later without losing your place.

The one rule that matters most

If you find something you do not recognise, do not delete it. Write down exactly what it says, and keep going.

Some things look alarming and are perfectly normal. A few look ordinary and are not. The wrong removal can stop your computer from working properly, and undoing it is much harder than writing down a name. When you have finished the checks, take your list to *Getting help* at the back of this guide (page 00). Nothing on that list needs to be dealt with today.

Two things first

Work or university computer? Do not use this guide — contact your IT department.

Missing money, someone can see your screen, or files that will not open? Click this link — *Getting help* (page 00)

Everyone else, begin at Step 1.

[FORMATTING: set this block in the GateBox style — body size + 2 pt, bold, space above and below, no border rule. Renders at 16 pt in the Standard 14 pt edition and stays two points above body in all five. Page number must be a Word cross-reference field, never typed.]

Quick-reference table

Every setting in this guide, and what it should be. Use it as a checklist now, and as a place to check back later.

The names below match what you will see on your own screen. Where Windows shows a slightly different word, the guide says so at that step.

#	Setting	Where it lives	Should be
1	Windows Update	Settings › Windows Update	Up to date, nothing waiting
2	Defender Real-Time Protection	Windows Security › Virus & threat protection › Manage settings	On
3	Tamper Protection	Same screen as above	On
4	SmartScreen	Windows Security › App & browser control	On, all parts
5	Defender Periodic Scanning	Windows Security › Virus & threat protection	On, only if you run another antivirus
6	Enhanced Phishing Protection	Windows Security › App & browser control › Reputation-based protection	On, all three parts
7	Firewall & network protection	Windows Security › Firewall & network protection	On for all three networks
8	BitLocker Data Encryption	Settings › Privacy & security › Device encryption	On, and the recovery key saved somewhere else
9	Windows Hello	Settings › Accounts › Sign-in options	PIN set up
10	Remote Desktop	Settings › System › Remote Desktop	Off, unless you truly use it
11	Advertising ID	Settings › Privacy & security › General	Off — your choice
12	Diagnostic Data	Settings › Privacy & security › Diagnostics & feedback	Required only — your choice
13	Edge Startup Boost	Edge › Settings › System and performance	Off
14	Windows Widgets	Right-click the taskbar › Taskbar settings	Off
15	Edge Password Saving	Edge › Settings › Profiles › Passwords	Off
16	Memory Integrity	Windows Security › Device security › Core isolation	On, if your computer allows it
17	Password Required on Wake	Settings › Accounts › Sign-in options	When PC wakes from sleep

#	Setting	Where it lives	Should be
18	Fast Startup	Control Panel › Power Options › Choose what the power buttons do	Off
19	Wake on LAN	Device Manager › Network adapters › Power Management	Off

Free explanations for every one of these are at gatewayguard.co/guide — one page per setting, with pictures.

Phase 1 — The basics

These are the settings that protect you day to day. If you only ever do one phase, do this one.

Step 1 — Windows Update

Why it matters. Updates close security holes that criminals already know about. An out-of-date computer is vulnerable to problems that were fixed months ago.

Where it lives: press the **Windows key**, type **Windows Update**, and press **Enter**.

Read the message at the top:

"You're up to date" — good. Move on.

"Updates available" or **"Restart required"** — click **Download** or **Restart now**, let it finish, then come back here.

"Checking for updates..." — wait a moment.

Then click "Check for updates" anyway, to be certain.

Click "Advanced options" and make sure these are **On**:

Receive updates for other Microsoft products

Get me up to date

Notify me when a restart is required

Check which Windows you have. Go to **Settings › System › About**.

It should say **Windows 11**, version 23H2, 24H2 or 25H2.

If it says Windows 10, that is a problem worth acting on. Windows 10 stopped receiving free security updates in October 2025. If your computer supports Windows 11, upgrading is worth doing. If it does not, this is a good conversation to have with someone you trust.

One thing to skip. If you see an update with **"Preview"** in its name, leave it. Those are early versions. The finished one arrives automatically the following month.

A note on 2026

Two things make this year worth checking carefully.

Windows computers built since about 2011 rely on security certificates that began expiring in late June 2026. Microsoft has been sending replacements through Windows Update. If your updates are current, this has already been handled and you will never notice it.

Microsoft also released an unusually large security update in June 2026. If your computer is asking to restart, let it.

Step 2 — Windows Security

Why it matters. Windows has good security built in. It is called Microsoft Defender, and for most home computers it is enough on its own.

Where it lives: press the **Windows key**, type **Windows Security**, and press **Enter**.

First, the six tiles

The main screen shows six tiles. **Each one should have a green check mark** or say "No action needed":

Virus & threat protection

Account protection

Firewall & network protection

App & browser control

Device security

Device performance & health

If any tile is yellow or red, click it and read what it says. It will name the specific problem. Fix that one thing, then come back. Do not move on while a tile is still yellow.

Virus & threat protection

Click **Virus & threat protection**, then **Manage settings**. Turn these **On**:

Defender Real-Time Protection — checks files as you open them.

Cloud-delivered protection — lets Windows ask Microsoft about suspicious files.

Automatic sample submission — sends unknown files for checking.

Tamper Protection — stops other programs from turning Defender off.

Pay attention to Tamper Protection. Harmful programs try to turn off your antivirus before doing anything else. If you find this turned off and you did not turn it off, that is worth noting on your paper.

Controlled folder access is also on this screen. It blocks unknown programs from changing your documents and pictures. It is genuinely protective, and it can also block a program you actually want. **Leave it off unless you are comfortable investigating when something stops working.**

Defender Periodic Scanning — setting 5

This one only applies if you run a different antivirus.

If another antivirus program is in charge, Defender steps aside and stops watching. **Periodic scanning** lets Defender still run an occasional check in the background as a second opinion, without the two programs fighting.

Where it lives: Windows Security › Virus & threat protection. If another antivirus is installed, you will see

Microsoft Defender Antivirus options on this screen with a **Periodic scanning** toggle.

Another antivirus installed → turn Periodic scanning **On**.

Defender is your only antivirus → the option is not shown, and does not need to be. Defender is already watching continuously.

Firewall & network protection — setting 7

Click **Firewall & network protection**. All three must say **On**:

Domain network

Private network

Public network

If any says Off, click it and turn **Microsoft Defender Firewall** on.

Why all three? Windows uses different rules depending on the network you are connected to. Turning one off leaves a gap that opens the moment you join that kind of network.

App & browser control — settings 4 and 6

Click **App & browser control**, then **Reputation-based protection settings**. Turn all of these **On**:

Check apps and files — warns before running something unrecognised.

SmartScreen for Microsoft Edge — blocks known bad websites.

Phishing protection — all three parts.

Potentially unwanted app blocking — both parts, Block apps and Block downloads.

SmartScreen for Microsoft Store apps

About Enhanced Phishing Protection — setting 6. Your screen calls this **Phishing protection**. Microsoft's own name for it is Enhanced Phishing Protection, and this guide uses the longer name so you can find their documentation if you want it.

What it actually does is worth understanding, because it is not the same as the website blocking above. It watches for your **Windows password** being typed where it does not belong — into a website, or into another program. If you are ever tricked into typing your Windows password into a convincing fake login page, this is the feature that warns you.

Its three parts warn you about typing your password into a bad site, about reusing it on other sites, and about storing it in a plain text file. **Turn all three on.**

Device security — setting 16

Click **Device security**. If you see **Core isolation**, click into it.

Memory integrity should be **On**.

If Windows says drivers are preventing it, **leave it off**. Forcing it can stop the computer from starting. This is worth revisiting after a round of updates.

If you turn it on, you may notice two new entries called `vmmem` and `vmwp` using memory. They belong to this feature and they are supposed to be there.

If another antivirus is installed

[DECISION 1 — the old Phase 4, which covered only Avira, is cut. This is the general version.]

Go to **Settings › Apps › Installed apps** and look for names like Norton, McAfee, Avast, AVG, Avira, Kaspersky, Bitdefender, ESET or Webroot.

For most home computers, Defender alone is the better arrangement. Two antivirus programs do not add up to twice the protection — they interfere with each other, and the one that came free with the computer is often a trial that expired long ago and now does nothing but ask for money.

If you want to remove one:

Settings › Apps › Installed apps, and find **every** entry from that company. They often install four or five separate pieces.

Uninstall each one. **Be patient.** Some take ten or fifteen minutes per piece and look frozen while they work.

If it will not uninstall, look for a **Repair** option first. Run the repair, restart the computer, then try the uninstall again. A half-broken installation is harder to remove than a working one.

If that fails, most of these companies publish a removal tool for exactly this situation. Get it from the company's own website, typed in directly — not from a search result, and not from any site that merely mentions the company's name.

Afterwards, open Windows Security › Virus & threat protection and confirm it now says **Microsoft Defender Antivirus**.

If Defender does not come back on by itself, restart once. It usually takes over as soon as it notices nothing else is in charge.

Step 3 — BitLocker Data Encryption

Why it matters. Encryption scrambles everything on the drive so it is useless to anyone who does not have your sign-in. Without it, someone who takes the computer can read every file on it, without needing your password at all.

Your screen may call this something else. Windows 11 Home says **Device encryption**. Windows 11 Pro says

BitLocker Drive Encryption. This guide says **BitLocker Data Encryption** because "BitLocker" is the word printed on the recovery key you may one day need.

Where it lives: Settings › Privacy & security › Device encryption. Turn it **On** if it is off. It works in the background and you can keep using the computer.

On Windows 11 Pro the path is **Settings › Privacy & security › Device security › BitLocker drive encryption**, and it should say **BitLocker on** beside your C: drive.

On either edition, you can also press the Windows key, type **BitLocker**, and open **Manage BitLocker**. The C: drive should show **On**.

What to expect. Encryption runs in the background and does not slow the computer down in normal use. The first time you turn it on it may take anywhere from thirty minutes to a few hours, depending on how much is on the drive. You can keep using the computer while it works.

The recovery key — read this part twice

Encryption comes with a **48-digit recovery key**. Windows may ask for it after a hardware change, a firmware update, or a repair. It is not a warning sign when that happens — it is normal, and it is exactly when you need the key.

Without the key, the files are gone. Not locked. Gone. No one can recover them. Not Microsoft, not a repair shop, not us.

Find your key now, before you need it:

On your phone or another computer, go to **account.microsoft.com/devices/recoverykey**

Sign in with the Microsoft account this computer uses.

You should see a 48-digit key listed for this computer.

Save it before encryption finishes, and in **at least two** of these places:

Your Microsoft account online — **account.microsoft.com/devices/recoverykey**. If you sign in to Windows with a Microsoft account, it may already be there.

Printed on paper, stored with your important documents.

On a USB stick, kept somewhere other than the computer bag.

In a password manager, saved as a secure note.

It must not be saved only on the encrypted drive. If the drive is what you cannot open, a key stored inside it is no help at all.

If the page shows no key, press the Windows key, type **Manage BitLocker**, choose **Back up your recovery key**, and pick **Save to a file** or **Print**. Then check the website again to confirm it arrived.

One situation that catches people out

If you sign in to this computer with a local account rather than a Microsoft account, Windows may still turn encryption on — but there is no Microsoft account for it to send the key to. **The key exists and is stored nowhere you can reach.**

How to tell: Settings › Accounts › Your info. If it says "Local account" and Device encryption says On, **use Manage BitLocker to back the key up right now**. This is the one combination that quietly leaves people without a key.

Step 4 — Your account and sign-in

Where it lives: Settings › Accounts › Your info.

Microsoft account or local account? Either works. A Microsoft account saves your encryption key automatically, which is a real advantage. A local account keeps more to yourself but makes Step 3 your responsibility.

Sign-in options — settings 9 and 17

Go to **Settings › Accounts › Sign-in options**.

Windows Hello PIN — setting 9. Set one up if you have not. Six digits or more.

A PIN is safer than a password here, which sounds backwards. The difference is that your PIN only works on this one computer — it is locked to a chip inside it. Someone who learns your PIN from across the room still cannot use it anywhere else. A password can be used from anywhere in the world.

Fingerprint or face — set up if your computer has them. If it says Unavailable, your computer does not have the hardware. That is not a problem.

Keep your password as a fallback, but use the PIN day to day.

Picture password — leave it off.

Password Required on Wake — setting 17. Near the top of this screen, find **If you've been away, when should Windows require you to sign in again?** Set it to **When PC wakes up from sleep**.

Why it matters: closing the lid is how most people "put the computer away". If it wakes straight to your desktop, then the lock on the front door is only as good as the room the computer is sitting in.

At the bottom of the screen, turn on **For improved security, only allow Windows Hello sign-in for Microsoft accounts on this device**.

Who else can use this computer

Go to **Settings › Accounts › Other users**.

There should be nobody here you do not recognise. On a computer only you use, the list should be empty.

If you see a name you do not know: write it down exactly. Do not delete it. Some accounts are created by the manufacturer and removing them can cause problems. Take the name to *Getting help* at the back (page 00).

Two-step verification — do this on your phone

This one change protects every other account you own, because your email address is how they all reset their passwords.

On your phone, go to **account.microsoft.com/security**

Sign in.

Turn **Two-step verification** on.

Set up **at least two** methods. Best first: an authenticator app, then a text message, then email.

Find **Recovery code**, generate one, and **save it with your BitLocker key**.

That last step matters more than it looks. If you lose your phone without a recovery code, you can be locked out of your own account permanently.

II STOPPING POINT

This is a good place to stop. Everything above is the core of it. If you do nothing else, the computer is meaningfully safer than it was this morning.

Phase 2 is about programs and browsers, and takes about another hour.

Phase 2 — Programs and browsers

This is where harmful software is usually found.

Step 5 — Look at what is installed

First, tighten where programs can come from

Settings › Apps › Advanced app settings › Choose where to get apps.

Set it to **"Anywhere, but warn me before installing an app that's not from the Microsoft Store"**, or stricter.

Avoid plain "Anywhere" — that setting installs things without ever warning you.

Now look at the list

Settings › Apps › Installed apps. Sort by **Install date**, newest first. Anything that arrived without your knowledge will be near the top.

Go down the list slowly. For each one, ask: do I know what this is?

Things worth writing down:

Programs you do not recognise at all

Plain names with no company behind them — "PDF Editor", "Video Converter", "PC Cleaner", "Music Player"

Extra toolbars or "search helpers"

Antivirus trials you never used

Before removing anything, find out who made it. Open **Control Panel › Programs and Features**, which shows a Publisher column. A dull name from a well-known company is usually something that came with your computer and is harmless.

Programs to remove on sight

If you see any of these, they are harmful. Do not open them. Go to the *If you found something harmful* section before removing them, because the order of steps matters.

Name	What it is
Anything by AppSuite	A family of programs that gives outsiders access to your computer
PDF Editor 1.x by AppSuite	Confirmed harmful
ManualFinder	Same family
OneLaunch	Same family
Wave Browser or Wave	Same family
Shift browser	Same family
A plain "PDF Editor" with no company name	Very often this family

How people get these. They are advertised at the top of search results for things like "free PDF editor". They look like ordinary free programs and install without complaint. Several security companies have confirmed that they can steal saved passwords and let someone else operate the computer remotely.

Also worth removing, though these are nuisances rather than dangers:

Fortect, formerly Reimage — sells repairs for problems it invents

Driver updaters and **registry cleaners** of any brand

Antivirus trials that came with the computer and were never used

Step 6 — Your browsers

Do this for each browser you actually use. Firefox has its own section at the back, because its settings are arranged differently.

Part A — Extensions

Type this into your browser's address bar: `chrome://extensions` for Chrome, or `edge://extensions` for Edge.

Every extension here should be one you chose deliberately.

Remove: anything named Coupon, Shopping helper, Deal finder, Search helper, Wave or Shift, and anything you do not recognise.

Look at what each one is allowed to do. "Read and change all your data on all websites" is a great deal of power. It is reasonable for a password manager you chose, or a well-known ad blocker. It is not reasonable for a coupon finder.

Part B — Search engine

Settings › Search engine. It should be Google, Bing or DuckDuckGo.

If it is a name you do not recognise, that is a sign something changed it without asking. Set it back, then open **Manage search engines** and delete the unfamiliar entries.

Part C — What opens when you start the browser

Settings › On startup.

Fine: "Open the New Tab page", or "Continue where you left off".

Not fine: "Open a specific page" showing an address you do not recognise. Remove it.

If a site keeps reopening on its own, it is one of three things: the tab is pinned (right-click it and choose Unpin), it is listed under On startup, or an extension is opening it — go back to Part A.

Part D — Stop browsers running when they are closed — setting 13

Why this matters. Edge and Chrome are both set, out of the box, to keep running after you close them and to start themselves when Windows starts. This uses memory you have paid for, and it is a common reason a computer feels slow for no obvious reason.

Microsoft Edge — setting 13, Edge Startup Boost:

Open Edge, click the **three dots** at the top right, choose **Settings**.

Click **System and performance**.

Turn **off Startup boost**.

Turn **off "Continue running background extensions and apps when Microsoft Edge is closed"**.

Close Edge completely.

Google Chrome:

Open Chrome, **three dots**, **Settings**, then **System**.

Turn **off "Continue running background apps when Google Chrome is closed"**.

Close Chrome completely.

On a computer with 8 GB of memory or less, Chrome's **Memory Saver** is worth turning on as well — Settings › Performance. It puts tabs you are not using to sleep.

Part E — Choose your default browser

Even with the settings above, Windows opens Edge when you click a link in Start menu search, in Outlook, or in a notification — unless you tell it otherwise.

Press the Windows key, type **Default apps**, press Enter.

Click your preferred browser.

Click **Set default** at the top.

Part F — Windows Widgets — setting 14

The news and weather panel on your taskbar runs browser processes in the background continuously, even if you never open it.

Right-click an empty part of the taskbar, choose **Taskbar settings**.

Turn **Widgets** off.

Part G — Programs that start with Windows

Open **Task Manager** — hold **Ctrl + Shift** and press **Esc**.

Click the **Startup apps** tab.

Look for browsers, and for anything you do not use daily.

Right-click each and choose **Disable**.

Disabling here does not uninstall anything. The program still works; it simply waits until you ask for it.

Part H — Saved passwords in your browser — setting 15

Chrome: Settings › Autofill and passwords › Google Password Manager › Settings. **Edge:** Settings › Profiles › Passwords.

Offer to save passwords → Off

Auto Sign-in → Off

Why turn off something so convenient? Because anything running on your computer can often read them. That is exactly what the programs in Step 5 are built to do. A separate password manager keeps them behind a second lock.

Do not delete the saved passwords yet. Move them somewhere else first — Phase 3 explains how. Turning off saving does not remove what is already stored.

Part I — Safe browsing in Chrome

Settings › Privacy and security › Security.

Choose **Enhanced protection** or **Standard protection**. **Never choose "No protection"**.

Part J — Check your sync account

Settings › You and Google › Sync. Confirm it is signed in to your own account and not one you do not recognise.

II STOPPING POINT

Phases 1 and 2 are the whole routine. Everything after this is either for a specific situation or optional.

If you found nothing harmful, skip the next section entirely and go to *Phase 4 — Privacy choices*.

Phase 3 — If you found something harmful

[DECISION 2 — the eight-step procedure is kept in full, behind this page.]

Stop and read this before starting

If Step 5 turned up one of the programs in the "remove on sight" table, this section explains what to do about it. It is longer and more demanding than anything so far.

Be honest with yourself about which of these describes you:

Get another person involved if:

You are not confident about the steps in Phases 1 and 2

You bank, invest, or do your taxes on this computer

You have more than a handful of accounts with saved passwords

Anything in *Getting help* at the back applies to you

You would rather not spend several hours on this

There is no shame in that. This section asks you to change passwords on twenty or more accounts and to delete files from system folders. It is work, and doing half of it is worse than not starting.

Right now, before deciding either way, do these two things:

Disconnect from the internet. Click the network icon near the clock and turn Wi-Fi off. This stops the program communicating while you decide.

Do not sign in to your bank on this computer until this is finished. Use your phone.
If you are going ahead, work through the steps in order. Skipping is how things get missed.

Step 1 — Remove the program

Settings › Apps › Installed apps. Find it, click the three dots, choose **Uninstall**.

Do not assume it is gone. These programs leave pieces behind deliberately. That is what the next three steps are for.

Step 2 — Run an offline scan

This scan runs before Windows finishes starting, so it can find things that hide from a normal scan.

Save your work and close everything.

Windows Security › Virus & threat protection › Scan options.

Choose **Microsoft Defender Antivirus (offline scan)**.

Click **Scan now**.

The computer restarts within a minute, shows a blue scanning screen for ten to twenty minutes, then starts normally. **This is expected. Do not turn it off.**

When it is done, open **Windows Security › Protection history** and read every entry. Each should say **Quarantined** or **Removed**. If any says **Allowed** or **Action needed**, click it and take the action offered.

Step 3 — Check for leftovers

Copy each line below into the address bar of File Explorer and press Enter:



```
%AppData%\PDFEditor  
%AppData%\AppSuite  
%LocalAppData%\PDFEditor  
%LocalAppData%\AppSuite  
%ProgramData%\PDFEditor  
%ProgramData%\AppSuite
```

"Location not found" is the answer you want. It means nothing is there.

If a folder does open: close it, go up one level, right-click the folder, and choose **Delete**. If Windows says it is in use, restart and try again. Then empty the Recycle Bin.

Step 4 — A second opinion

Different scanners find different things.

Type **malwarebytes.com** into your browser directly. **Check the address bar reads exactly that** before downloading anything.

Download **Malwarebytes Free**.

During installation, decline the free trial of the Premium version. Uncheck the box, or choose Skip.

Why declining matters. Windows allows only one antivirus to be in charge at a time. If the Premium trial activates, it takes over and Windows turns Defender's real-time protection off — leaving you with a confusing arrangement when the trial ends. **The free version, used occasionally, never does this.**

Run a scan. It takes twenty to forty-five minutes.

Quarantine everything it finds. It presents results in groups — keep clicking Quarantine until it stops asking.

Restart when asked.

Afterwards, check Windows Security › Virus & threat protection still says Microsoft Defender Antivirus.

If it does not, open Malwarebytes › Settings › Security and turn its real-time protection off.

Note on the free version: it is licensed for personal, non-commercial use. And its Deep Scan does not check for the deepest kind of hidden program regardless of what its settings say — which is why Step 2 comes first and is not optional.

Step 5 — Sign out everywhere — from your phone

Do this on your phone, not on this computer.

Google: myaccount.google.com › Security › Your devices › Sign out of all devices.

Microsoft: account.microsoft.com › Security › Sign me out everywhere.

Then check account.live.com/Activity for sign-ins from places you have never been.

Why this step exists. These programs can copy the invisible tokens that keep you signed in. Changing a password does not always cancel those. Signing out everywhere does.

Step 6 — Check your email

For each email account, from your phone:

Recent sign-in activity — anything from a country you have not visited?

Sent folder — messages you did not write?

Trash — password reset emails you did not ask for?

Forwarding and filters — Gmail: gear icon › See all settings › Filters and Blocked Addresses, and Forwarding and POP/IMAP.

A forwarding rule you did not create needs acting on today. It means someone is receiving copies of your mail, including password resets. If you find one, remove it, change that password immediately, and get a person involved.

If everything looks normal, then your passwords may have been taken but nobody has used them yet. Step 7 is what closes that door.

Step 7 — Change your passwords

Assume every password saved in a browser on this computer is known to someone else.

You do not have to do them all today. Work in order of what would hurt most.

This week — the ones that matter:

Email accounts. **These first, always** — every other account resets through them.

Microsoft, Google, Apple

Banks, credit cards, PayPal

Tax and health accounts

Anything to do with work

This month: shopping sites with a card saved, and your main social accounts.

When you get to them: everything else.

For each account, ideally on your phone:

Sign in with the old password.

Go to Security settings and change the password.

Let a password manager generate the new one — a strong password you cannot remember is fine, because you no longer need to.

Turn on two-step verification if offered.

Sign out of other sessions if the site offers it.

Ask yourself as you go: have I used this in the past year? If not, consider closing the account instead. An account you never use is one more place your details sit.

Step 8 — Finish clearing the browser

Once your important passwords are moved, go back to Step 6 Part H and **delete the saved passwords** from the browser's list.

II STOPPING POINT

If you have worked through Phase 3, stop here. Password changes are better done over several sittings than rushed in one.

Phase 4 — Privacy choices

[DECISION 5 — these are presented as choices with a recommendation, and now match what Checkup does.]

These are not security settings and nothing here makes your computer easier to break into. They control how much Microsoft learns about how you use it. Reasonable people choose differently.

Our recommendation is to turn both down, and Checkup does so with your permission. Neither affects how Windows works.

Advertising ID — setting 11

What it is: a number that lets apps show advertising based on what you do on this computer.

Where it lives: Settings › Privacy & security › General.

Turn off **Let apps show me personalised ads by using my advertising ID**.

What changes: you see the same number of adverts. They are simply less tailored to you. No restart is needed.

How to undo it. Same screen, turn the toggle back on.

This is a preference, not a security requirement. Leaving it on does not put the computer at risk. The choice is yours.

Diagnostic Data — setting 12

What it is: information sent to Microsoft about how the computer is running.

Where it lives: Settings › Privacy & security › Diagnostics & feedback.

Set it to **Required diagnostic data**, and turn off **Tailored experiences**.

What changes: nothing you will notice. Windows still receives what it needs to stay reliable.

How to undo it. Same screen, set it back to **Optional diagnostic data**.

A preference, not a security requirement, exactly as above.

Remote Desktop — setting 10

This one is a security setting, and it is on this page because it is usually off already.

What it is: a feature that lets someone operate this computer from another one, over the internet.

Where it lives: **Settings › System › Remote Desktop.**

Turn it off unless you genuinely use it. Most home users never have. It is a door, and a door nobody uses is one that should be locked.

How to undo it. Same screen, turn Remote Desktop back on.

On Windows 11 Home, this feature is not included and you may not see the option. That is fine — it means it was never available.

Phase 5 — Two settings most guides miss

Fast Startup — setting 18

What it is: a feature that makes the computer start faster by not fully shutting down. When you choose Shut down, Windows saves part of itself to disk and restores it next time.

Why turn it off. Because "shut down" no longer means shut down. Some updates do not finish installing, and problems that a restart would clear survive instead. On a computer with encryption, the drive is also left in a state that is less protected than a genuine shutdown.

You lose a few seconds of startup time. That is the whole cost.

Where it lives:

Press the Windows key, type **Control Panel**, press Enter.

Go to **Hardware and Sound › Power Options › Choose what the power buttons do.**

Click **Change settings that are currently unavailable** at the top. Until you click this, the boxes below are greyed out.

Under **Shutdown settings**, uncheck **Turn on fast startup.**

Click **Save changes.**

What to expect. Starting up takes about ten to thirty seconds longer on a modern computer, a little more on an older one. In exchange, every start is a genuinely fresh one and updates finish installing properly.

Your scan reminders are unaffected. The monthly and quarterly reminders are scheduled inside Windows and do not depend on this setting.

How to undo it. Same place, tick the box again, Save changes.

Wake on LAN — setting 19

What it is: a feature that lets the computer be woken up over the network while it is asleep.

Why turn it off. In an office this is useful — the technicians wake machines overnight to update them. At home, nobody needs it, and a computer that can be woken from elsewhere is a computer that can be reached when you think it is off.

It is also why a laptop sometimes wakes in a closed bag and grows warm.

Where it lives:

Right-click the **Start** button, choose **Device Manager.**

Expand **Network adapters.**

Right-click your adapter, choose **Properties**.

Open the **Power Management** tab.

Uncheck **Allow this device to wake the computer**.

Click **OK**.

Do this for each adapter listed — most computers have two, one for Wi-Fi and one for the network cable.

Turning off one and not the other leaves the door open.

No restart is needed. The change takes effect straight away.

If a tab or option is missing, that adapter does not support the feature and there is nothing to turn off.

Do I need to change anything in the startup screens before Windows loads? No. The Windows setting above is the one that governs this, and it is enough. You may read elsewhere that there is also a setting in the screens that appear before Windows starts. That is true on some computers, and it does not override what you have just done. We do not recommend going near those screens — they differ on every make of computer and a wrong change there is much harder to undo.

If you actually use this feature, keep it. Some people turn a computer on in another room from a phone app so it is ready when they get there. That is a real use, and this is a recommendation rather than a requirement — which is why Checkup asks rather than simply changing it.

If you keep it on, make it safer. In the same Power Management tab, tick **Only allow a magic packet to wake the computer**. A magic packet is a specific wake-up message meant only for your computer. With that ticked, ordinary network traffic can no longer wake it.

How to undo it. Same place — Device Manager, Network adapters, right-click the adapter, Properties, Power Management — and tick the box again. Nothing is lost by turning it off and back on.

One warning worth carrying with you. Nobody legitimate will ever phone you, or send a pop-up, asking to connect to your computer to fix a problem you did not report. Remote-access requests that arrive out of the blue are among the most common frauds aimed at older adults, according to the Federal Trade Commission's *Protecting Older Consumers* report. Hang up, and close the window.

Going forward

These habits matter more over time than any single setting.

Never install a free utility from a search result. This is how nearly all of it arrives. The advertisements at the top of the page are bought, including by the people in Step 5. **Type a company's address in directly**, or use the Microsoft Store.

Use a password manager. Look for one that encrypts so the company itself cannot read your passwords, has a working free version or clear pricing, has apps for every device you use, and publishes independent security audits. Search for a comparison in the current year; this changes.

Run Malwarebytes Free about once a month, and decline the trial every time.

Run an offline scan every few months, or any time the computer starts behaving oddly.

Turn on two-step verification wherever it is offered, and save the recovery codes with your BitLocker key.

Look at your browser extensions a few times a year. They accumulate.

Keep your recovery keys off the encrypted drive. Paper, password manager, USB stick.

Check the browser settings again every few months. Windows and browser updates have been known to turn Startup boost and background running back on.

Watch for these names in future: AppSuite, ManualFinder, OneLaunch, Wave, Shift, TamperedChef. They travel together.

Keeping the computer from getting slow

A slow computer is a security problem, because a slow computer is one people start turning protections off to speed up.

Look at Startup apps every few months — Task Manager › Startup apps. Turn off things you do not use daily.

Pick one browser for daily use. Running three at once can use several gigabytes on its own.

On 8 GB computers, turn Chrome's Memory Saver to Maximum, and close chat programs like Teams, Slack, Discord and Spotify when you are not using them. Each uses a surprising amount.

If one browser is using several gigabytes, close it and reopen it. It is usually one tab or one extension.

If something looks suspicious — quick answers

What you found	What to do
A program you do not recognise, from a well-known company	Probably came with the computer. Write down the name; leave it alone.
A program with a plain name and no company	Search the name plus the word "malware". If results agree, treat it as harmful.
"PDF Editor", "ManualFinder", or anything by AppSuite	Harmful. Go to Phase 3.
Your search engine changed to something unfamiliar	Something changed it. Reset it, and delete the entry.
A device you do not recognise in your Google account	Sign out of everything, change the password from your phone, turn on two-step verification.
An email forwarding rule you did not create	Serious. Remove it, change that password, and get help.
A sign-in from a country you have never visited	Serious. Same as above.
Windows Security says "Action needed"	Click it and do what it asks.
Edge keeps reopening after you close it	Recheck Step 6, Parts D, F and G.
A browser using several gigabytes	Close it, reopen, and look at the extensions.

Getting help

Most of this guide is routine. A few situations are not, and this section covers them.

If your files will not open and something is demanding payment

Do not pay, and do not restart the computer. Restarting can destroy the one thing that sometimes allows files to be recovered.

This is ransomware, and it needs someone with hands on the machine today. Take the computer to a local repair shop, or call someone who can come to you. Do not use this guide first.

If money is missing from an account

Call the bank before anything else, using the number printed on your card — not a number from an email, a search result, or a phone call you received.

Fraud is time-sensitive in a way that computer settings are not. Come back to this guide afterwards.

If someone can see your screen

If a former partner, or anyone you are afraid of, may be watching this computer, **the changes in this guide can be noticed by them** — and being noticed is the danger, not the setting.

Use a different device — a friend's phone, or a computer at a library — and speak to someone who handles this before changing anything here.

The National Domestic Violence Hotline — thehotline.org

The Coalition Against Stalkerware — guidance written for exactly this situation

If someone else is in your email

If messages you did not write have been sent from your account, or a sign-in appears from a place you have never been, **that is happening now rather than in the past.**

Change that password from a different device, and turn on two-step verification. Then work through Phase 3 of this guide, which covers what else to check.

If this is a work or university computer

Contact your IT department and do not use this guide. They own these settings, they have their own procedures, and on a managed computer a change made without them can cause problems that are not yours to fix.

Who counts as help

A relative or friend who is comfortable with computers. A local repair shop with a physical address and reviews you can read. Your internet provider's support line for anything to do with the connection itself.

Be careful who you call

If a pop-up, a phone call, or an email tells you your computer is infected and gives you a number, that is the scam itself.

Real security warnings never ask you to phone anyone. Nobody legitimate will contact you out of the blue asking to connect to your computer.

Advanced — optional

[**DECISION 3** — the PowerShell commands and Task Scheduler steps are kept here, behind this wall, rather than in the main walkthrough.]

Nothing in this section is required. The guide is complete without it. It is here for readers who are comfortable with technical tools, or who have been asked for this information by someone helping them.

If a stranger has asked you to run any of these, stop. That is a common way people are talked into damaging their own computers.

Edge's scheduled tasks

Edge schedules itself to run periodically. Turning these off stops it restarting itself in the background.

Press the Windows key, type **Task Scheduler**, press Enter.

Click **Task Scheduler Library** on the left.

Find entries with **MicrosoftEdgeUpdate** in the name.

Right-click each and choose **Disable**. **Do not choose Delete** — disabling can be undone.

Edge still updates normally. This only stops it launching itself.

PowerShell commands

Right-click **Start** and choose **Terminal**.

List installed Store apps matching a word:



Get-AppxPackage *keyword* | Select Name, Publisher, PackageFullName

List all installed programs:



Get-WmiObject -Class Win32_Product | Select Name, Vendor, InstallDate

Remove a specific Store app:



Get-AppxPackage *exactname* | Remove-AppxPackage

Browser addresses worth knowing

Edge: `edge://settings/system` · `edge://extensions` · `edge://settings/help`

Chrome: `chrome://settings/system` · `chrome://settings/performance` · `chrome://extensions` · `chrome://settings/searchEngines`

Folder shortcuts

Type this	It means
<code>%AppData%</code>	C:\Users\yourname\AppData\Roaming
<code>%LocalAppData%</code>	C:\Users\yourname\AppData\Local
<code>%ProgramData%</code>	C:\ProgramData
<code>%UserProfile%</code>	C:\Users\yourname

Websites worth bookmarking

account.microsoft.com/devices/recoverykey — your BitLocker key

account.microsoft.com/security — two-step verification

myaccount.google.com — Google account security

haveibeenpwned.com — check your email against known breaches

gatewayguard.co/guide — free explanations for all nineteen settings

Firefox

Skip this section if you do not use Firefox.

Firefox arranges its settings differently, so it gets its own walkthrough. **Type each address below into the address bar** and press Enter.

F1 — Extensions. `about:addons` › Extensions. Same rules as Step 6 Part A: remove anything you did not choose. Check Themes and Plugins too.

F2 — Tracking and safe browsing. `about:preferences#privacy`. Set Enhanced Tracking Protection to **Strict**. Further down, confirm all four boxes under **Deceptive Content and Dangerous Software Protection** are ticked. Turn on **HTTPS-Only Mode** for all windows.

F3 — Search engine. `about:preferences#search`. Confirm it is a name you know, and remove unfamiliar entries below.

F4 — Startup. `about:preferences`. Untick **Open previous windows and tabs**.

F5 — Data collection. `about:preferences#privacy`, then **Firefox Data Collection and Use**. Untick all three boxes.

F6 — Sponsored content. `about:preferences#home`. Untick **Recommended by Pocket, Sponsored stories** and **Sponsored shortcuts**.

F7 — Encrypted DNS. `about:preferences#privacy`, at the bottom. Choose **Increased Protection**. This hides which websites you look up from your internet provider.

F8 — Profiles. `about:profiles`. There should be one profile, or only ones you created. **If you see an unfamiliar profile, do not remove it — write down what it says.** Some harmful programs create a second Firefox profile to collect information quietly.

F9 — Updates. `about:preferences#general`. Leave **Automatically install updates** on.

F10 — Saved passwords. [about:preferences#privacy](#) › Logins and Passwords. Untick **Ask to save logins and passwords**. Move existing ones to a password manager before deleting them.

F11 — If Firefox feels slow. [about:performance](#) shows which tab or extension is responsible.

Firefox quick reference

Setting	Where	Should be
Open previous windows and tabs	about:preferences	Off
Enhanced Tracking Protection	about:preferences#privacy	Strict
Deceptive content protection	about:preferences#privacy	All four on
HTTPS-Only Mode	about:preferences#privacy	On, all windows
Data collection	about:preferences#privacy	All off
Pocket and sponsored content	about:preferences#home	All off
Search engine	about:preferences#search	One you recognise
Encrypted DNS	about:preferences#privacy	Increased Protection
Saved passwords	about:preferences#privacy	Off
Profiles	about:profiles	Only ones you know about

Words you may meet

[DECISION 6 — memory-upgrade terms removed. They belong to a different conversation.]

Two-step verification (2FA) — Signing in with two things instead of one: your password, plus a code from your phone. It stops nearly every attempt to break into an account using a stolen password.

AppSuite — The company name behind a family of harmful programs. Anything from AppSuite should be treated as dangerous.

Authenticator app — A phone app that produces a fresh six-digit code every thirty seconds, used for two-step verification. Safer than receiving a code by text.

BitLocker — Windows' built-in encryption. Scrambles the drive so it cannot be read without your sign-in.

BitLocker recovery key — A 48-digit number Windows creates when encryption is turned on. Needed if Windows ever cannot unlock the drive on its own. **Must be stored somewhere other than that drive.**

Chromium — The open-source engine underneath Chrome, Edge, Brave and several other browsers. Programs like Slack and Teams are built on it too, which is why they use so much memory.

Cloud-delivered protection — Lets Defender ask Microsoft's servers about a file it has not seen before.

Controlled folder access — Stops unapproved programs changing your documents and pictures. Strong protection against ransomware, and occasionally blocks something you wanted.

Defender — Microsoft Defender, the security software built into Windows. Antivirus, firewall and web protection together.

Encryption — Scrambling information so it is meaningless without the key.

Extension — A small add-on that changes how your browser behaves. Some are useful; some read everything you do.

Firewall — Controls which connections in and out of your computer are allowed.

Memory Integrity — A Windows feature that walls off the core of Windows from harmful software. Also called Core isolation.

Offline scan — A scan that runs before Windows finishes starting, so it can find things that hide during normal use.

Password manager — A program that stores your passwords behind one strong password, and creates new ones for you.

Phishing — A message or website pretending to be someone you trust, to get you to type your password.

PIN — A short code that signs you in to one specific computer. Safer than a password here, because it works nowhere else.

PUP — Potentially Unwanted Program — Not quite harmful, not welcome either. Fake cleaners, nuisance toolbars, programs that arrive alongside something else.

Ransomware — Software that locks up your files and demands payment.

Real-time protection — Defender checking each file as it is opened or downloaded, rather than only during a scan.

SmartScreen — Warns you before opening a website or program with a bad reputation.

Startup boost — An Edge feature that starts Edge quietly when Windows starts.

Tamper Protection — Stops other software turning Defender off. Harmful programs try this first.

TamperedChef — The name security researchers gave the family of harmful programs described in Step 5.

Task Manager — The Windows tool showing what is running. Ctrl + Shift
Esc.

TPM — A chip inside the computer that stores encryption keys safely. BitLocker and your PIN both rely on it.

Widgets — The news and weather panel on the taskbar. Runs browser processes in the background even when unopened.

Windows Hello — Windows' sign-in system using a PIN, fingerprint or face.

Windows Update — How Windows repairs security problems. The single most important thing to keep current.

End of guide.

This guide describes procedures carried out on real Windows 11 computers, including removal of the AppSuite "PDF Editor" family, removal of conflicting antivirus software, and browser background-activity prevention.

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